OpenAI ChatGPT Key Free: How to Get and Use a Free API Key

Free API Key · Use Guide | Updated October 28, 2026

If you are searching for an **OpenAI ChatGPT key free** option, you can create your own OpenAI API key through the official API platform and use it for software projects, websites, chatbots, automation tools, and other applications. The important difference is that an API key is an authentication credential, while free API usage or credits are separate from the key itself. OpenAI also manages ChatGPT and API billing separately, so a ChatGPT subscription and API usage should not be treated as the same service.

An OpenAI API key is useful when you want your own application to communicate with OpenAI programmatically. Instead of manually opening ChatGPT and entering prompts, a developer can build an application that sends requests through the API and displays the resulting output inside a custom interface.

For anyone searching for a **free ChatGPT API key** or **free OpenAI API key**, the best starting point is to create a personal API credential through the official platform and then check the billing and usage options available to that account.

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What Does OpenAI ChatGPT Key Free Mean?

The search phrase **OpenAI ChatGPT key free** combines several related ideas.

"OpenAI" refers to the platform providing the API, while "ChatGPT" is the AI product

many users already know. The "key" is the credential used by software to authenticate API requests. "Free" can refer to the user's desire to start without paying for the credential itself, free credits that may be available to an account, or simply an inexpensive way to experiment with the API.

An **OpenAI API key** is not the same thing as free API credits.

Is There a Free OpenAI ChatGPT API Key?

You can create your own OpenAI API key through the API platform without buying a key from another person.

However, a free API key should not be interpreted as an unlimited free API plan. API access, credits, and billing are separate considerations.

OpenAI currently states that **ChatGPT and the API platform have separate billing systems**.

How to Get an OpenAI ChatGPT Key Free

Step 1: Sign In to Your OpenAI Account — Start with an OpenAI account that you control.

Step 2: Open the API Key Page — Open the API platform and navigate to the API key management area.

Step 3: Generate a New API Key — Create a new secret API key for your application or project.

Step 4: Save the Secret Securely — When OpenAI creates the key, the full secret value is shown at that time.

Step 5: Connect the Key to Your Application — Store the key in an environment variable rather than writing it directly inside your source code.

Free ChatGPT API Key vs OpenAI API Key

For practical purposes, the credential you create for programmatic OpenAI API access is an OpenAI API key. People often use "ChatGPT API key" because they want to build an application with ChatGPT-like AI capabilities.

OpenAI's billing documentation makes the separation particularly clear: ChatGPT and the API platform have their own billing systems.

Does ChatGPT Free Include a Free API Key?

A ChatGPT account gives you access to the ChatGPT product according to the features available to your account and plan. The API is intended for applications that communicate programmatically with OpenAI.

OpenAI states that the two products use separate billing systems.

Understanding Free API Access

An API key is an authentication mechanism. It does not represent a fixed amount of free usage.

API usage can depend on the model, features, account configuration, and applicable billing arrangements.

How to Use Your Free OpenAI API Key

A typical application contains three main components:

User interface → Your server → OpenAI API

The user interacts with your website or application. Your server receives the request and uses the OpenAI API credential to communicate with the API.

Using an OpenAI Key With Python

For example:

```
import os
api_key = os.environ.get("OPENAI_API_KEY")
if not api_key: raise RuntimeError("OPENAI_API_KEY is not configured")
```

This example reads the key from an environment variable without exposing the secret in the Python file.

Using an OpenAI API Key With JavaScript

A simple server-side configuration might read the environment variable like this:

```
const apiKey = process.env.OPENAI_API_KEY;
if (!apiKey) { throw new Error("OPENAI_API_KEY is not configured"); }
```

Browser-side JavaScript should not contain the actual secret key.

Can You Use an OpenAI ChatGPT Key for a Website?

The process can look like this:

Visitor enters prompt → Your website sends it to your backend → Backend authenticates with OpenAI → OpenAI API processes the request → Backend

returns the response → Visitor sees the answer

Free ChatGPT API Key for a Custom Chatbot

For example, a chatbot website could include:

A custom chat window
User authentication
Conversation history
Your own branding
Database storage
Custom application instructions
Usage limits
User-specific features
Analytics

How to Keep Your ChatGPT OpenAI Key Private

Use OPENAI_API_KEY — Store your secret in an environment variable rather than writing it directly into source code.

Keep the Key Out of GitHub — Never commit a secret API key to a repository.

Keep the Key on Your Backend — The frontend should communicate with your backend.

Monitor API Usage — Regularly checking API usage can help you identify activity that does not match your application.

What to Do If Your OpenAI API Key Is Exposed?

A simple recovery process is:

1. Delete the exposed key.
2. Review recent API usage.
3. Create a new API key.
4. Update the application.
5. Check public repositories and source files for additional copies.
6. Continue monitoring the account.

Should You Use a Shared Free OpenAI API Key?

Creating your own key is preferable to using a shared credential.

OpenAI does not recommend sharing personal API keys. For team collaboration, OpenAI recommends project-based API keys and separate credentials for appropriate users, products, or environments.

Using Separate Keys for Different Projects

For example, you could organize your projects like this:

Development project → Development key

Testing project → Testing key

Production project → Production key

This arrangement makes it easier to identify which application is generating API usage.

What Does "Free" Really Mean for OpenAI API Users?

A free API key means you can create an API credential through the platform without purchasing a key from a reseller.

It does not mean that every API request will always cost nothing.

OpenAI ChatGPT Key Free for Beginners

A basic project can teach you:

How API authentication works
How environment variables work
How to send requests
How to handle API responses
How to handle errors
How to protect credentials
How to monitor API usage

Troubleshooting an OpenAI API Key

Common causes include:

An old key is stored in your environment.
A new key was created but the application still uses the old one.
The key was deleted.
Different parts of the application use different credentials.
The wrong project or organization is being used.

How to Replace an Old OpenAI API Key

If you need to replace a key, create the new credential first and update your application.

After confirming that the application works with the replacement, delete the old key if it is no longer needed.

Frequently Asked Questions

How can I get an OpenAI ChatGPT key free? You can create an OpenAI API key through the official API platform.

Is a free ChatGPT API key available? You can create your own OpenAI API key, but an API key should not be confused with unlimited free API usage.

Is ChatGPT API free? ChatGPT and the OpenAI API are separate products with separate billing systems.

Where can I create an OpenAI API key? OpenAI provides an API key management page.

Does ChatGPT Plus include API credits? ChatGPT and the API platform use separate billing systems.

Can I use my OpenAI API key on my website? Yes. The key should remain on your backend rather than being placed in browser-side code.

Can I share my free OpenAI API key? OpenAI does not recommend sharing personal API keys.

Where should I store my OpenAI API key? OpenAI recommends storing the key in an environment variable such as OPENAI_API_KEY.

What happens if someone gets my OpenAI API key? An exposed API key can be used for unauthorized API activity through your account.

Can I put an OpenAI API key in HTML or JavaScript? A secret API key should not be

exposed through browser-side code.

Can I create multiple OpenAI API keys? Yes. Multiple keys can be useful for separating projects, environments, teams, or features.

Is an OpenAI API key the same as ChatGPT? No. The API key is a credential used by software to authenticate with the OpenAI API, while ChatGPT is the user-facing AI product.

Does an OpenAI API key provide unlimited free requests? No. The API key is an authentication credential and does not represent an unlimited free-use plan.

Final Thoughts

Searching for an **OpenAI ChatGPT key free** is usually the first step for someone who wants to experiment with OpenAI-powered software without making the setup complicated. The correct approach is to create your own OpenAI API key through the official API platform, store it securely, and then connect it to your application through a protected backend.

The most important distinction is between the **API key** and **free API usage**. Your key authenticates requests, while your API account determines how those requests are billed or covered by any available credits.

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